

Keeping a Promise

By pushing ahead with the deal, Manmohan Singh has re-established India's credibility in the eyes of the world and also given it a chance to meet the stiff deadline

■ **By Raj Chengappa with Saurabh Shukla**

After the bruising battle in Parliament, Prime Minister Manmohan Singh has emerged as his own man. He not only established his leadership in domestic politics but as importantly, by keeping his word and that of India's on the civilian nuclear deal, he has restored the country's credibility in the eyes of not just the US but the entire world.

India's international stature had eroded considerably after months of foot-dragging and indecision over the deal. Especially because nuclear experts in many nations opined that India had got the better of the US in the deal and were foxed as to why Delhi's political establishment continued to look a gift horse in the mouth. Many commentators had concluded that while India had ambitions of being a great power, it just didn't seem to have the right stuff to achieve it. The trust vote victory in Parliament signalled that India is ready again. As the prime minister said soon after the vote, "It augurs well for the country and for India's efforts to secure a place in the comity of nations."

A day earlier, a confident Manmohan told an aide, "I am glad that I made the deal an issue. It has united and galvanised not just the party but also our allies and the Government." It seemed to have transformed the prime minister too after he took what he called "one last shot" at the deal. Another aide observed, "Manmohan seemed mentally liberated. It was as if he had listened to his inner voice and was finally keeping his word." His positive body language invigorated government officials too and even before the voting was over, they were working out strategies to persuade key countries to support India when the deal comes up for clearance at both the International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA) and the Nuclear Suppliers Group (NSG) in the coming months.

If the Government seemed in a tearing hurry, it is because time now is the real enemy for the deal. The UPA-Left joint committee to sort out differences over the deal had eaten up precious months in which the Government could have got it past both the IAEA and the NSG if the original timetable was maintained. Now it would have to race against the clock to ensure that the deal would get to the US Congress before it goes into recess by September-end. The idea is to have the deal cleared before the term of US President George Bush comes to an end in January 2009 and also before a new Congress is voted in around the same time. After that, the risks for the deal to be operationalised grow as there is no guarantee that the next administration would be as keen as Bush and his aides to see it through.

There were still plenty of hurdles to cross and Shyam Saran, the prime minister's special envoy for the deal, said: "It's going to be an uphill task to cover the last mile in the time frame left." Even as the votes were being counted in Parliament, Saran had begun his tour of world capitals to persuade nations to back India. There still remained plenty of resistance among many nations over what a European diplomat called, "such a sweet deal for India". The deal would end India's nuclear isolation by allowing other countries to export reactors, fuel and equipment meant for civilian nuclear power to India. It also allowed India to develop its nuclear weapons programme unhindered. The US had to amend a domestic law which had prohibited nuclear trade with a country which had not signed the Nuclear Non-Proliferation Treaty (NPT) to enable American entities to trade with India. Known as the Hyde Act, it was followed by a bilateral 123 Agreement between India and the US which laid down the terms for such trade between them.

It was at this point that the Left called a halt to

For the deal, time is the real enemy. India is hoping to cross all the remaining hurdles before the term of President George Bush runs out. The worry is that the next administration may not be as enthusiastic.